

Chicago Tribune



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THURSDAY, FEBRUARY 6, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

THE TRUMP ADMINISTRATION

USAID recall spurs anger

Workers fear being stranded after the White House abruptly pulls staffers amid its attempt to dismantle most of agency

Experts decry damage done to decades-old aid organization meant to shore up US security through humanitarian efforts



EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicagoans join others in protests against Musk power grab, Project 2025

People chant during a rally in Chicago's Federal Plaza on Wednesday to stop the Trump administration's funding freeze, heralded by brazen actions from billionaire Elon Musk. Demonstrators gathered in cities across the country, the result of a grassroots movement organized on social media platforms.

IMMIGRATION

Amid federal deportation threats, mayor accepts Republican congressman's invitation to testify before US House on Chicago's sanctuary city protections

By Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson will testify before Congress next month in a Republican-led hearing on sanctuary cities, his office confirmed Wednesday.

Last month, Oversight Committee Chair U.S. Rep. James Comer, R-Ky., opened an investigation into Chicago and three other cities with Democratic mayors, requesting they all appear to answer questions on what he described as “their misguided and obstructionist policies” blocking local police from immigration enforcement.

Johnson and his corporation counsel have spent the past week demurring on whether he would accept,

Turn to Mayor, Page 6



A freshman chief executive who has carved his space as the most progressive big-city mayor in the U.S., Mayor Brandon Johnson's brand back home could gain much-needed momentum if he effectively spars with Republicans looking to score points against deep-blue Chicago's pro-immigrant values. EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

TRANS RIGHTS

Ill. mother says teen's chest surgery was canceled after Trump's executive order

By Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

An Illinois teenager's chest surgery was canceled last week after President Donald Trump issued an executive order seeking to end gender-affirming care for minors, his mother said in a court document filed Wednesday.

Trump's executive order issued last week told federal agencies to ensure that institutions, such as hospitals, that receive federal research grants stop offering gender-affirming care to people under the age of 19. That order also instructed the secretary of the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services to take action, potentially related to Medicaid and other programs, to end gender-affirming care for people

younger than 19.

The types of gender-affirming care the executive order seeks to block include medications to delay puberty, hormone therapy and surgery.

The executive order has ignited confusion among hospitals and other providers of gender-affirming care across the country, with some hospitals and clinics canceling such care. On Wednesday, Illinois Attorney General Kwame Raoul and the attorneys general of 14 other states said in a statement that they will protect gender-affirming care. They said in the statement that federal dollars remain available to institutions that provide gender-affirming care despite the executive order, and that Illinois and

Turn to Surgery, Page 6

Trump's Gaza plan widely panned

President Donald Trump's proposal to take over the Gaza Strip and permanently resettle its Palestinian residents was swiftly rejected and denounced Wednesday. **Nation & World**

Musk moves fast on government

Billionaire Elon Musk's incursions into at least half a dozen agencies have challenged the authority of Congress and possibly breached civil service protections. **Nation & World**

AG Bondi to review Trump cases

Pam Bondi was sworn in Wednesday as attorney general and immediately called for investigations into Department of Justice cases against the president. **Nation & World**

GENERAL ASSEMBLY

New law aims to help relatives of foster kids in state's care

By Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Gov. JB Pritzker on Wednesday signed a bill aimed at making it easier for relatives of children in the state's care to get licensed as foster parents and receive financial assistance, creating a law advocates say could help thousands of families and children in Illinois.

“Wherever possible, a family member who already knows and

loves a child can provide stability and familiarity, and most often leads to the least amount of disruption and trauma for a child,” Pritzker said at the signing ceremony in the Illinois State Capitol, flanked by lawmakers and other backers of the bill. “The research proves it. Youth in care, living with relatives, dramatically improves mental health outcomes, educational attainment, social function, child happiness and the list goes on.”

Heidi Mueller, who over the

weekend marked her first year as director of the Illinois Department of Children and Family Services, said the new law has special significance for her.

She recounted how her grandmother died of cancer when her mother was a little girl, and that her grandfather was too preoccupied coping with his own grief and managing the struggling family farm to care for his daughter. So, Mueller said, her mother was taken in by her aunt, even

though the woman was a widow and was raising her own daughter by herself.

“In doing that, she taught my mom really powerful lessons about love, about sacrifice, about taking care of each other, about mutual responsibility, and my mom passed those lessons on to me, and those lessons are what led me right here to this spot today,” Mueller said, speaking at a lectern in the governor's ceremonial office.

The measure signed by the

governor, which received bipartisan support when it passed through the General Assembly, provides incentives for relatives of children in DCFS care to maintain a home for those kids as an alternative to the children being placed in foster care with non-family members. The new law requires DCFS to seek federal funding to start a “kinship navigator program” to assist relatives

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TODAY'S WEATHER



High 41 Low 19

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 14

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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